

High Expectations for Every Student

Melody Morrison, who recently retired as special education case manager at Mooresville High School, has seen the impact on her students of high expectations on the part of everyone in the school community. “I have students who might not have graduated five years ago who have graduated. In our school culture, they’re not just my kids anymore, they’re everybody’s kids—all teachers throughout the school are doing their best for them and expecting them to do their best,” she says.

Michael Fullan has emphasized the power of the moral imperative in his work on school reform and stressed that system-wide adherence to the moral imperative must always underlie high expectations for students. Fullan advises that when we care for and believe in students, including at-risk learners, high expectations follow as a natural consequence.

Our administrators have read and discussed two of Michael Fullan’s books, *All Systems Go* and *The Six Secrets of Change*, in our leadership team meetings. The ideas in these books have brought clarity to our purpose as school leaders, galvanized our team beliefs, and helped us collectively embrace the moral imperative as we strive to live up to our motto, *Every Child, Every Day*.

Our students are constantly encouraged and acknowledged—the essential foundation for high expectations. Just as parents encourage, coach, nurture, and love their children, at MGSD we embrace a caring and loving disposition toward students. Our expectations are part of that caring, and our students know it.

We make both the expectations and the caring clear to students every day. When I visited her class, Susie Hudson, English department co-chair at Mooresville Middle School, said privately to me but out loud for all her students to hear, “We have great students, and we have very high expectations for them, Dr. Edwards, and I know they will rise to the challenge. In fact, when you and I are old, we’ll be fortunate to have these students in charge.”

As I walked the campus of N.F. Woods Advanced Technology & Arts Center, sister school of Mooresville High School, with Principal Dee Gibbs, he stopped several students to ask how they were doing or if they had followed up on an assignment. He generally finished up a conversation by saying, “You know we care about you,” or “Dr. Edwards, you can be proud of this young man.” Our students receive a constant flow of support from teachers, administrators, and staff. Every time I visit classes at N.F. Woods, teachers always acknowledge their students for working hard and for just being great kids.



Eighth-grade students at Mooresville Middle School

Special Education Students



Listen to biology teacher Samone Graham describe how she helps special needs students succeed.

High expectations—along with digital tools, data-driven decision making, and our culture of caring—have allowed us to make substantial progress in closing achievement gaps, including for special education students. The organizational functions and personalization offered by digital tools have had a very beneficial impact on this group of students, who often suffer from poor organizational skills and need to work at their own pace and skill level.

STUDENT FEEDBACK *“I think that since we have had the laptops, my productivity has gone up ten-fold regarding school work. While there are some distracting features to access on the laptop, I think most would agree with me that the laptops are beneficial to our learning. I have a lot more organization, and it is harder to make excuses to procrastinate, as I have all of what I need right in front of me most of the time.”*

—Mooresville High School student

One data point we are particularly proud of is that in 2011, 92 percent of third graders who received special education services scored proficient on the state end-of-grade math exam—a very rigorous application-based test—only three percentage points below the score for all students.

English Language Learners

Digital conversion is helping English learners meet expectations and thrive along with their peers. Lenoa Smith, curriculum resource teacher at Park View Elementary School, has been very excited by the opportunity digital conversion provides to her students. “So many students go home and the only language spoken is Spanish, and the parents struggle with learning English as well,” she said. “But with the laptops and our software, students can listen to the text in English and Spanish, and so can the parents. This is really helping them reinforce language acquisition skills at home as well as at school.”

Minority Students

During an administrative meeting a couple of years ago, one of our high school department chairs commented that Mooresville High School had always had high expectations for students. But Vanessa Peoples, the second-grade chair from Rocky River Elementary, spoke emotionally about her experience as an African American student growing up in Mooresville at a time when high expectations were not the norm for her and her friends. We acknowledged the truth of her experience, and Vanessa said, “But it’s a new day now—new hope—with high expectations for everyone.”

PARENT FEEDBACK *“Our students are very proud of the laptops. I saw some students at a bus stop, and I think they’re standing a little taller—they know someone cares about them.”*

—MGSD parent and former school board member

Culture of Student Collaboration

One year, at the senior class project presentations, a young man walked up to give his presentation, accompanied by another student, who kept his hand on the boy’s shoulder during the presentation. The young man stumbled over